

*Bêl-šar-ušur*⁶³² = *Bêl-shar-u-tzur*. It is quite possible, however, that *Bêl-šar-ušur* may in practice have been pronounced something like *Bêl-shar-tzur*, i.e. with a suppression of the initial vowel of the final element (the imperative of the verb *našâru*) of the name. The approximation of *Bêl-shar-tzur* to Belshazzar is very apparent. Baruch's Balthasar⁶³³ and Josephus' Baltasar⁶³⁴ cannot be compared so convincingly with the Babylonian form of the name. Hence the fifth chapter of Daniel is linked with original cuneiform documents by the name Belshazzar. With reference to the second assertion, a cuneiform text states that Nabonidus empowered Belshazzar with 'the kingship' in the third year of his reign.⁶³⁵ All accessible cuneiform documents capable of throwing light upon the situation indicate that Belshazzar occupied this high position until the fourteenth year of Nabonidus' reign and the probability is that he functioned as co-regent until the end of the reign. There is no room for doubt that Belshazzar ruled in the kingdom next to Nabonidus. The writer of the fifth chapter of Daniel comports with cuneiform data in picturing the chief character of his narrative as having enjoyed kingly dignity.

(c) The fact that *Nebuchadrezzar* is referred to as the father of *Belshazzar* is one of the main features of the fifth chapter of Daniel.⁶³⁶ This should be interpreted with the following facts in mind. Babylonian texts and Greek data indicate that Nabonidus' ancestry and early life fitted him for marriage with a daughter of Nebuchadrezzar.⁶³⁷ Such connection with the reigning dynasty may be regarded as explaining Nabonidus' accession to the throne in the most satis-

⁶³² The meaning of the name is 'O Bêl, protect the king!' For the form בלסראצר see Lidzbarski, *Ephemeris für semitische Epigraphik*, III, p. 117, and Lidzbarski, *Altaramäische Urkunden aus Assur*, p. 15f. The former work refers to the occurrence of the name upon a stone statue, thought to have been found in Egypt; the latter refers to the occurrence of the name on two clay tablets bearing Aramaic records.

⁶³³ Baruch 1: 11, 12.

⁶³⁴ Josephus, *Antiq. Jud.* X, 11, 2f. Note the βαλτασάρ of LXX, Daniel 5.

⁶³⁵ *BHT* pp. 84, 88, col. II, line 20. See p. 106f of this monograph.

⁶³⁶ Daniel 5: 2, 11, 13, 18, 22. The form of the name used is *Nebuchadnezzar* and not *Nebuchadrezzar*. This is not a serious deviation from the cuneiform pronunciation. For Semitic interchange of *r* and *n* see Brockelmann, *Grundriss der vergleichenden Grammatik der semitischen Sprachen* I, pp. 224, 225, 226, 228, 229, 230, 231. It must be admitted, however, that if the form *Nebuchadrezzar* were present in the fifth chapter of Daniel it would represent the original cuneiform more accurately.

⁶³⁷ See pp. 16-33.